Lesson 10: Grammar: Present Tense, Compound Sentences, Adjectives

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 1: People and Places

Adapted from People and Places - An Intermediate Integrated-Skills Module for English Learners by Sara Ferguson, Grossmont College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): 2.6: Grammar: Present Tense Verbs; 2.7: Grammar: Compound Sentences; 2.8: Grammar: Descriptive Adjectives.

In this lesson

You will learn when to use the simple present and the present continuous, and how to spell -ing and -s forms. You will write compound sentences and study descriptive adjectives, including adjective order and comparatives.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Choose between the simple present and the present continuous.
- Spell -ing and -s/-es forms correctly.
- Write compound sentences with a comma and a coordinating conjunction (FANBOYS).
- Choose between -ed and -ing adjectives and put adjectives in the right order.
- Make comparative adjectives and use them with "than".

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
simple present	verb form for facts, habits and permanent situations	I live in San Diego.
present continuous	am/is/are + verb-ing, for actions now or for a short time	We are strolling on the beach.
stative verb	a verb for a state, not an action; usually not used with -ing	I own a car.
coordinating conjunction	a joining word: for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so (FANBOYS)	..., so San Diego became part of the U.S.
compound sentence	two clauses (subject + verb) joined by a comma + FANBOYS	In 1821, Mexico won independence from Spain, and San Diego became part of Mexico.
descriptive adjective	a word that tells more about a noun	San Diego has sandy beaches.
linking verb	a verb (be, seem) that can be followed by an adjective	The beaches in San Diego are sandy.

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
comparative adjective	an adjective that compares two nouns; "than" follows it	Black Mountain is higher than Mount Helix.

Rules and explanations

Simple present or present continuous?

- Simple present: I/you/we/they **live**; he/she/it **lives**. Negative: don't/doesn't + verb. Question: Do/Does ... + verb?
- Present continuous: am/is/are + verb-ing: Right now, I **am driving** to Grossmont College.
- Use the **simple present** for general facts, routines and habits, permanent situations, and stative verbs (like, own, think = have an opinion).
- Use the **present continuous** for actions happening right now, actions in progress (this semester), new or temporary actions, and actions changing over time.
- "She works at Ross Dress for Less": she has worked there for a while and plans to stay. "She is working at Ross Dress for Less": a new job, or she plans to change jobs soon.
- Stative verbs are usually not continuous: I own a car (NOT I am owning a car). Some stative verbs change meaning in the continuous: "I think Balboa Park is beautiful" (opinion) but "I am thinking about Balboa Park" (an activity in your mind).

Spelling: -ing

- Most verbs: add -ing (read → reading, say → saying). Verbs ending in -y: no change (study → studying, play → playing).
- Ending in -e: drop the -e (wake → waking, tape → taping). Ending in -ie: ie → y (die → dying, lie → lying).
- One syllable ending consonant-vowel-consonant (CVC): double the last letter (stop → stopping, sit → sitting, ban → banning). Never double w, x or y.
- Two syllables ending CVC: double only if the stress is on the last syllable: be·GIN → beginning, re·FER → referring. But LIS·ten → listening, CAN·cel → canceling (US; British: cancelling).

Spelling: -s / -es (he/she/it verbs and plural nouns)

- Most words: add -s (walks, runs; hats, trees).
- Consonant + y: y → ies (carries, studies, flies; skies, bellies). Vowel + y: just -s (plays).
- Ending in s, x, ch, sh: add -es (passes, fixes, watches, bashes; messes, taxes, patches, dishes).

Compound sentences

- A **clause** has a subject and a verb. Join two clauses with a **comma + coordinating conjunction** (FANBOYS: for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so): SV, + FANBOYS + SV. The comma comes before the conjunction.
- NOT compound: a **compound subject** (two subjects, one verb) or a **compound verb** (one subject, two verbs). They have only one clause, so there is no comma before "and".

Descriptive adjectives

- An adjective tells more about a noun (what kind, how many, which one): rolling hills, majestic mountains.
- It comes **before a noun** (San Diego has sandy beaches) or **after a linking verb** (The beaches in San Diego are sandy).
- Common endings: -able/-ible, -ful, -less, -ic, -ive, -al, -ous, -ish (incredible, helpful, helpless, realistic, creative, natural, suspicious, childish).
- **-ed adjectives:** a person feels it (She felt excited). **-ing adjectives:** the thing causes the feeling (The movie was amazing). Pairs: interested/interesting, tired/tiring, amazed/amazing, fascinated/fascinating, bored/boring.
- **Order:** determiner, opinion, size, age, shape, color, origin, material, purpose + noun. Use only two or three adjectives before a noun.

Comparative adjectives

- Compare two nouns; "than" follows: San Diego, CA is larger than El Cajon, CA.
- One syllable: + -er (richer, deeper). Ends in -e: + -r (larger). One syllable ending CVC: double the consonant (bigger).
- Two syllables ending in -y: y → -ier (easier, happier).
- Two or more syllables: more + adjective (more diverse, more difficult). A few two-syllable adjectives can also take -er (quieter); check a dictionary.
- Irregular: good → better, bad → worse, far → farther/further, little → less, many → more.

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - In Standard Arabic, one present form can mean both "I live" and "I am living". English has two: a habit or fact (I live) and an action now or for a short time (I am living).
> - Arabic uses "from" after a comparative. English uses "than": larger than El Cajon (not "larger from El Cajon").

Practice

1. Warm-up. What is the difference between the two tenses? "Every day, I travel from Tijuana to San Diego." / "Right now, I am driving to Grossmont College."

2. Write the -ing form: read, say, study, play, wake, tape, die, lie, stop, ban, begin, refer, listen, cancel.

3. Write the -s/-es form: walk, run, carry, fly, pass, fix, watch; nouns: sky, belly, tax, dish, tree.

4. Simple present or present continuous? Use the verb in brackets.

- a) It never …….. (snow) in El Cajon.
- b) She …….. (drive) from Mexico to San Diego once a week.
- c) Right now, we …….. (stroll) on the beach.

- d) This semester, she …… (work) at a restaurant to help pay for school.
- e) Rent in San Diego …… (increase) rapidly these days.
- f) I …… (not like) the weather in San Diego.
- g) I …… (own) a car.
- h) I …… (think) Balboa Park is beautiful.
- i) Right now, I …… (think) about Balboa Park.
- j) He …… (live) in San Diego for now; he moved here a few months ago.

5. Compound sentences. (Section 2.7 in your lesson material.)

- a) In the three sentences about the history of San Diego, find the subjects and verbs. How many does each sentence have? Where is the comma?
- b) Why are "The San Diego Zoo and Balboa Park began in 1915" and "Every weekend we go to the beach and enjoy the water" NOT compound sentences?
- c) Write three compound sentences about your city, with "and", "but" and "so". For another explanation, watch the compound sentences video (see "Watch online").

6. -ed or -ing? Use the verb in brackets.

- a) (frighten) The mask is …… . I feel …… when I look at the mask.
- b) (interest) I am …… in the history of Iraq. Iraq has an …… history.
- c) (confuse) The homework is …… . All of the students felt …… by the homework.
- d) (excite) Disneyland is …… . My kids are so …… about going to Disneyland.

7. Adjective order. Describe a dress, a car and a mountain. Use two adjectives in the correct order: A …… …… dress / A …… …… car / A …… …… mountain. Choose from the list "Adjectives To Choose From" in section 2.8 (blue, huge, beautiful, vintage, Italian…).

8. Comparatives.

- a) In "San Diego, CA is larger than El Cajon, CA" and "Black Mountain is higher than Mount Helix", which two nouns are compared? What is the comparative adjective? What word follows it?
- b) Write the comparative: large, rich, deep, big, easy, happy, hungry, diverse, difficult, majestic, populated, good, bad, far, little, many.

Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me what I do every day and what I am doing these days. Correct my simple present and present continuous."
- "Ask me about the history of my city. I will answer in compound sentences with and, but or so."
- "Name a place. I will compare it with my city using -er or more … than. Correct me."

Read aloud

1. be·GIN → be·GIN·ning

2. re·FER → re·FER·ring
3. LIS·ten → LIS·ten·ing
4. CAN·cel → CAN·cel·ing
5. ma·JES·tic → more ma·JES·tic
6. di·VERSE → more di·VERSE
7. In 1821, Mexico won independence from Spain, and San Diego became part of Mexico. (↘)
8. Every day, I travel from Tijuana to San Diego. (↘)
9. Right now, I am driving to Grossmont College. (↘)
10. San Diego, CA is larger than El Cajon, CA. (↘)

Writing task

From the book's slides for 2.6: describe your neighborhood in five sentences in the simple present (general facts, your feelings, events that happen regularly). Then go to a favorite place nearby (a park, a cafe, or even your front step) and write five sentences in the present continuous about what is happening right now. Ask your tutor to correct your ten sentences.

Watch online

- Simple present (English with Jennifer): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bkA8dFYMAZc
- Present continuous (English with Jennifer): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=p1NbkB77QYY
- Simple present or present continuous (Anglo-Link): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=AEBRIBtq7q0
- Stative verbs (engVid): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nFdXIenda98
- Stative verbs, lists and exercises: https://www.perfect-english-grammar.com/stative-verbs.html
- Compound sentences with coordinating conjunctions: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Bp2YRRotE1o
- What are adjectives? (Socratica): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wz5InHzfY68
- Adjective order (Woodward English): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=46_M9mS71R8

Answer key

1. Simple present: a habit (every day). Present continuous: an action happening now (right now).
2. reading, saying, studying, playing, waking, taping, dying, lying, stopping, banning, beginning, referring, listening, canceling (British: cancelling) (book)
3. walks, runs, carries, flies, passes, fixes, watches; skies, bellies, taxes, dishes, trees (book)
4. a) snows b) drives c) are strolling d) is working e) is increasing f) don't like g) own h) think i) am thinking j) is living (book sentences)
5. a) Spanish explorers / sailed, the first residents / were; Mexico / won, San Diego / became; the United States / won, San Diego / became: 2 subjects and 2 verbs each. The comma comes before but, and, so (book). b) The first has a compound subject (two subjects, one verb: began). The second has a compound verb (one subject, we; two verbs: go, enjoy) (book). c) (example answer) My city has a big market, and many people shop there. My city is old, but it has many new buildings. It is very hot in summer, so many people go to the sea.
6. a) frightening, frightened b) interested, interesting c) confusing, confused d) exciting, excited (book)
7. (example answer) a beautiful blue dress (opinion + color); a small Italian car (size + origin); a brand-new yellow car (age + color); a huge gray mountain (size + color).
8. a) San Diego and El Cajon: larger. Black Mountain and Mount Helix: higher. "Than" follows (book). b) larger, richer, deeper, bigger, easier, happier, hungrier, more diverse, more difficult, more majestic, more populated, better, worse, farther/further, less, more (book)

My notes